

Your Personalised Advanced Health Assessment Report



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PRIVATE & CONFIDENTIAL

Jane Smith
8 Bridge Road
London E62AG

Your ref: **UAT1ADV3NFUPZPU9E**

Date: 31/07/2026

Dear Jane

Thank you for choosing **DCA - TEST DOMAIN**.

We would always advise you to discuss any health or wellbeing concerns you have with your GP in addition to the information provided in this report.

Please take your time reading through the full report. A simple flag system of green, amber and red as illustrated below should make the report easier for you to follow. An information flag is also used for any sections of interest which are not based directly from your results.



No concerns



Attention



Attention



Information

Yours sincerely

Bibin Paul
DCA - TEST DOMAIN

Summary



Attention (2)



No concerns (18)



Information (1)



Blood Pressure



Body Mass Index



Cardiovascular
Disease Risk
(QRISK®3)



Central Obesity



Lipid Profile



Heart Rate



Uric Acid



Bone Health
Profile



Musculoskeletal



Liver



HbA1c - Diabetes
Test



Full Blood Count



Iron Studies



Thyroid



Kidney Function



Vitamin D



CRP



Smoking



Physical Activity
Questionnaire



Alcohol US-
AUDIT



Diet



Reviewer Notes

XXXXX



Blood Pressure

The recommended blood pressure (also referred to as BP) is typically around 120/80 mmHg.

The upper number, known as the systolic pressure, is always the higher number. It represents the pressure in the blood vessels when the heart beats. The lower number, known as the diastolic pressure, indicates the pressure within the blood vessels between heartbeats when the heart is at rest.

According to medical guidelines, high blood pressure (or hypertension) is generally accepted as being persistently 140/90 mmHg or over. It is very common and often does not cause any symptoms. Knowing you have it may prevent life-threatening cardiovascular problems such as stroke or heart attack.

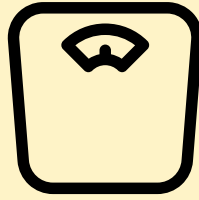
Your blood pressure reading was **100 mmHg / 50 mmHg**

Your blood pressure was lower than one would tend to see in clinical practice. Sometimes, this may cause you to feel dizzy when you stand up suddenly or move from a lying position to sitting or standing, like when you are getting out of bed.

Low blood pressure can be a normal variant, sometimes seen in young, fit, active people, and it needs no further attention.

However, it can be associated with other acute medical problems and should really be considered on an individual basis. You could recheck it in a pharmacy or at home if you have access to a home monitor. It is helpful to have a variety of readings under different circumstances. If your readings are consistently this low or you feel unwell, you could speak to your doctor.

Alternatively, it may just have been lower than normal on your test day.



Body Mass Index

Your Body Mass Index (BMI) is a measure of your body fat based on your height and weight. While it's considered a crude measure, it remains widely used as a reference.

Your height was measured at **174** cm and your weight was measured at **87** kg

Based on these measurements, your Body Mass index is **28.74** kg/m² (Normal range: 18.5 - <25)

This result falls into the overweight category. If left unchecked, it can be associated with, or worsen, many diseases in the future, such as diabetes, high blood pressure, depression or certain types of cancers.

BMI is simply a calculation in which the weight in kilograms is divided by the height in metres squared. It is widely used as an estimate of body fat and is accurate for most people. Just bear in mind that it is less accurate if you have very high or very low muscle mass, but for most people, it is a useful indication of whether you are at a healthy weight.



Cardiovascular Disease Risk (QRISK®3)

The QRISK®3 algorithm was developed by doctors and academics working in the UK National Health Service and is based on routinely collected data from many thousands of GPs across the country. It calculates your risk of having a heart attack or stroke over the next ten years and is suitable for people who do not already have a diagnosis of heart disease or stroke and are not taking statins.

Your risk of having a heart attack or stroke within the next 10 years is: **1.4%**

Your body mass index was calculated as **28.74** kg/m²

How does your 10-year score compare?

10-year QRISK®3 score	1.4%
The score for a healthy person with the same age, sex at birth and ethnicity*	2.4%
Your relative risk is**	0.6
Your QRISK®3 Healthy Heart Age***	40

* This is the score of a healthy person of your age, sex and ethnic group, i.e. with no adverse clinical indicators and a cholesterol ratio of 4.0, a stable systolic blood pressure of 125, and BMI of 25.0.

** Your relative risk is your risk divided by the healthy person's risk.

*** Your QRISK®3 Healthy Heart Age is the age at which a healthy person of your sex and ethnicity has your 10-year QRISK®3 score.

QRISK3-2017 Disclaimer Notice The calculations above make use of the QRISK3-2017 algorithm and related source code that was released by ClinRisk, Ltd under the GNU Lesser General Public License and has the following disclaimer: The initial version of this file, to be found at <http://svn.clinrisk.co.uk/opensource/qrisk2>, faithfully implements QRISK3-2017. ClinRisk Ltd. have released this code under the GNU Lesser General Public License to enable others to implement the algorithm faithfully. However, the nature of the GNU Lesser General Public License is such that we cannot prevent, for example, someone accidentally altering the coefficients, getting the inputs wrong, or just poor programming. ClinRisk Ltd. stress, therefore, that it is the responsibility of the end user to check that the source that they receive produces the same results as the original code found at <https://qrisk.org>. Inaccurate implementations of risk scores can lead to wrong patients being given the wrong treatment.

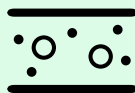


Central Obesity

Central obesity, as determined by waist measurement, has been shown to increase the likelihood of developing many chronic conditions such as: cardiovascular disease (CVD), stroke, type 2 diabetes, and some cancers.

Your Waist measurement was **35** cm (Low risk of CVS disease: 30 - 94)

This result is associated with a low risk of developing a chronic disease. To remain at this level, it is important to ensure a healthy lifestyle and diet.



Lipid Profile

Cholesterol is a fatty substance found in the blood. It is mostly made by the liver from the fatty foods we eat and is a normal part of a functioning body but having an excessively high level of cholesterol in your blood can have a serious effect on your health. It can increase your risk of having a heart attack or stroke.

Cholesterol is comprised of “good fats” and “bad fats”, generally referred to as a lipid profile. Ideally, your total cholesterol should be under 5 with higher good fats and lower bad fats.

The ratio of total cholesterol to HDL may also be calculated. This is your total cholesterol level divided by your HDL level and the lower it is kept the better.

"Good fat" – the higher the better

HDL (High density lipoprotein) a low HDL level can increase your risk of heart disease.

"Bad fat" – the lower the better

LDL (Low density lipoprotein) is the main part of cholesterol involved in making little fatty lumps inside your blood vessels called atheroma.

Triglycerides, when raised, are part of a condition called metabolic syndrome, which includes high blood pressure, increased belly fat, low HDL, and high blood sugar. Often people underestimate the extent to which high triglycerides increase your risk of cardiovascular disease and most are unaware that a very high level also has effects on the liver, the pancreas and even has an association with dementia.

Your **Total Cholesterol** was **2.5** mmol/L (Normal range: 2.3 - 5).

Your **HDL** was **2** mmol/L (Normal range: 1.03 - 2.38).

Your total cholesterol to HDL ratio was: **2.5** mmol/L : **2** mmol/L = **1.3**

Your **LDL** was **2** mmol/L (Normal range: 0.1 - 2.6).

Your **Triglycerides** were **1.5** mmol/L (Normal range: 0.84 - 1.71).

All your results are normal.



Heart Rate

Your heart rate (as measured by your pulse) was **80** bpm (Normal range: 60 - 89).

Your heart rate was normal.



Uric Acid

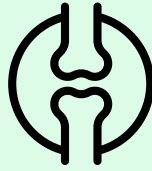
Uric acid is a normal part of blood.

When uric acid levels are high, crystals can form within joints and can result in gout and arthritis. The pain associated with uric acid crystals can come on very quickly (acute gout) or it may take time. Blood levels of uric acid are better at predicting long-term complications than an acute attack.

High levels of uric acid have been associated with other medical conditions such as diabetes, kidney problem and cardiovascular disease.

Your uric acid level was **400** umol/L (Normal range: 250 - 450).

Your uric acid level is within the normal range. This does not exclude a diagnosis of gout if you have symptoms.



Bone Health Profile

Bone has multiple functions. Apart from making the skeleton, they also make blood cells and various hormones and help control mineral levels.

To do this bones interact with the kidneys, the gut, the blood and the glands. These interactions are complex and our knowledge is constantly changing.

Looking at bones can involve x-rays, scans and blood tests. A combination of these may be needed to fully explore a person's bone health if there is a concern.

Your bone health profile will look at bone related chemicals. Abnormal levels of any of these can contribute to weak bone structure.

Your calcium was **2.5** mmol/L (Normal range: 2.1 - <2.6).

Your calcium is normal.

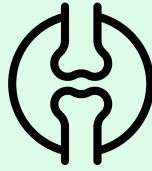
Your magnesium was **1** mmol/L (Normal range: 0.66 - 1.07).

Your magnesium is normal.

Your phosphate was **1.5** mmol/L (Normal range: 0.8 - 1.55).

Your phosphate is normal.

Although blood tests are helpful in checking the health of your bones, if you have a specific worry regarding osteoporosis risk or undiagnosed bone pain, you need to have this investigated separately, often with a bone scan or X-Ray.



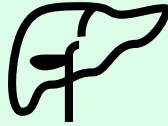
Musculoskeletal

Musculoskeletal pain is pain that affects our muscles, ligaments, tendons, bones and joints and the causes of this pain can be quite varied. For instance, muscle tissue can be damaged by the wear and tear of daily life and through injury. Pain is a complex symptom that affects us both physically and mentally. Your response to pain is as individual as you are.

This section aims to raise awareness of any pain or discomfort you may be experiencing, when and why it occurs, and to encourage you to consider simple lifestyle changes, such as taking breaks from prolonged computer use, adjusting your desk height or breaking up long car journeys, to improve your overall well-being.

You indicated that you do not seem to be suffering from any aches and pains at present, which is positive. If you experience pain or discomfort in the future, the following guidance may help.

Aches and pains that last for a few days are relatively common and may resolve spontaneously with rest and simple pain relief. However, there are a few symptoms you should watch out for that require medical attention, such as severe pain, pain that affects your ability to perform basic daily tasks, or symptoms that affect your ability to do your job.



Liver

Liver function is typically evaluated by measuring the level of various components in your blood, which fall into 2 broad categories.

Bilirubin is produced by the liver and is the main component of bile that is secreted by your liver to help digest food. If there is a disruption to this process, then the level of bilirubin in your blood increases.

The other components of your liver function tests (LFTs) are enzymes that work in your liver (and are found to a much lesser extent in other tissues). If your liver cells become damaged or inflamed, then these enzymes can rise in your blood tests. However, the pattern in which they rise will depend on the underlying cause; for example, some conditions may cause a greater increase in certain enzymes than others.

The enzymes measured to assess liver function are:

- ALT (alanine transaminase) breaks down proteins into amino acids. It is a sensitive marker for inflammation or problems within the liver cells.
- AST (aspartate transaminase) plays a role in breaking down proteins into amino acids. It will usually be fluctuating in tandem with other liver enzymes in response to inflammation.
- ALP (alkaline phosphatase) plays a role in protein breakdown but is also produced by cells outside the liver. ALP can indicate not only liver inflammation but also a blockage in bile drainage or in other systemic conditions.
- GGT (gamma-glutamyl transferase) is an enzyme necessary for the processing and synthesis of some proteins. It can be released into the bloodstream if there is structural damage to the liver or the bile collecting system.

Your Bilirubin level is **20** umol/L (Normal range: 1 - 21).

Your ALT level is **40** IU/L (Normal range: 10 - 45).

Your AST level is **30** IU/L (Normal range: 5 - 36).

Your ALP level is **100** IU/L (Normal range: 30 - 120).

Your GGT level is **50** IU/L (Normal range: 1 - 55).

Your test results are all normal.



HbA1c - Diabetes Test

HbA1c is a blood test that shows your average blood sugar levels over the past 2–3 months. It is commonly used to:

Check for pre-diabetes or diabetes

Monitor the effectiveness of treatment in those living with diabetes.

Your HbA1c result was **40** mmol/mol (Normal range: 20 - 42).

This is within the current normal range.



Full Blood Count

A full blood count, or FBC, is a blood test used to check a person's general health as well as screen for specific conditions, such as anaemia.

The test will check for the number of red cells, white cells and platelets in the blood among other things. Red cells carry oxygen around the body and haemoglobin makes up part of the red cells. White cells are used by the body to fight infections. Platelets are important for clotting blood and stopping bleeding.

Your haemoglobin (anaemia test) was **16** g/dL (Normal range: 13.3 - 17.7).

This is a normal result.

Your platelet count was **400** x10e9/L (Normal range: 150 - 450).

- This is a normal result.

Your white cell count was **8** x10e9/L (Normal range: 4 - 10).

- This is a normal result.

White cell differential

This is a breakdown of the different types of White Blood Cells which have various different roles in immunity and fighting infection.

Your neutrophil count was **6** x10e9/L (Normal range: 2 - 7).

- Neutrophils are the most common type of white blood cell. They respond to infection and to inflammation, such as an injury. In particular, they become raised when fighting a bacterial infection. They also respond to physical exercise and stress. Your neutrophil count was normal.

Your lymphocyte count was **2** x10e9/L (Normal range: 1 - 3).

- Lymphocytes are the type of white blood cell that particularly fights viruses. Your lymphocyte count was normal.

Your basophil count was **0.05** x10e9/L (Normal range: 0.02 - 0.1).

- Basophils make up a very small proportion of your white cell count. They are involved in protecting your body against infection. Your basophil count was normal.

Your eosinophil count was **0.5** x10e9/L (Normal range: 0.02 - 0.5).

- Eosinophils are a type of white blood cell that contain histamine. They function mainly in allergic reactions although they also can become increased in parasitic infections. Your eosinophil count was normal.

Your monocyte count was **1** x10e9/L (Normal range: 0.2 - 1).

- Monocytes are scavenger cells that ingest and remove foreign particles from your blood and inside your body. Your monocyte count was normal.



Iron Studies

Estimation of your iron stores is an important part of your overall health assessment.

Low iron stores can be linked to anaemia and are relatively straightforward to address once a cause is identified. Iron overload can point to issues in other areas of your health which may require attention, such as haemochromatosis or an underlying inflammatory disease.

Your iron studies also include the following tests:

Ferritin is the form in which iron is stored within the cells of the body.

Transferrin is a protein found in the blood that binds iron. Transferrin saturation is measured as a percentage of the amount of transferrin bound to iron and reflects the amount of iron circulating in the bloodstream.

Your ferritin result was **200** ug/L (Normal range: 22 - <276).

Your iron result was **30** umol/L (Normal range: 11.6 - 31.3).

Your transferrin saturation result was **50** % (Normal range: 20 - 50).

Both your iron stores and the capacity of your blood to carry iron are normal. You are not anaemic.



Thyroid

Your thyroid is a small gland at the front of your neck. Its job is to produce thyroid hormone (also called T4 or thyroxine) which controls your metabolism.

The pituitary gland controls the thyroid gland by making thyroid stimulating hormone (TSH).

TSH increases the work rate of the thyroid gland, so if the level of thyroid hormone becomes low, the pituitary will usually produce more TSH to increase thyroid hormone production.

If the level of thyroid hormone is too high, the pituitary will reduce the amount of TSH it makes in order to reduce the level of thyroid hormone again.

Excessive thyroid hormone increases your metabolism so that you may sweat, increase your heart rate or feel agitated. Inadequate thyroid hormone decreases your metabolism so you may feel cold, have a slow heart rate or feel exhausted. There are many other symptoms in addition to these.

Your Thyroxine (T4) level was **20** pmol/L (Normal range: 10.5 - 22).

Your level of Thyroid Stimulating Hormone (TSH) was **4** uIU/mL (Normal range: 0.27 - 4.2).

These results are normal.

T3 (or triiodothyronine) is the active form of thyroid hormone. Your thyroid gland produces T4 which is then converted to T3 in your tissues to have the biological effect on your body. T4 is the most relevant result, as it represents the overall activity of your thyroid gland.

Your T3 result was **3** pmol/L.

This is a normal result.

Thyroid peroxidase antibodies (TPOAb) can be present in auto-immune thyroid disease such as Graves' disease and thyroiditis. It is usually requested to help identify the cause of a known thyroid abnormality. It can also be elevated in healthy people.

Your thyroid peroxidase antibody level was **5** IU/mL.

This is a normal result.

Thyroglobulin antibodies (TgAb) are usually requested to help identify the cause of a known thyroid abnormality. TgAb target the protein scaffold in the thyroid gland. If somebody is known to have an inflamed thyroid gland, the

thyroglobulin test can help determine the cause of this inflammation. It can be elevated in some auto-immune diseases.

Your thyroglobulin antibody level was **100** IU/mL.

This is a normal result.



Kidney Function

The kidneys regulate the amount of fluid and salts in our bodies and eliminate certain waste products. They also play an important role in regulating blood pressure.

A kidney function test includes various components to evaluate the performance and efficiency of the kidneys.

The components used to measure kidney function are:

- Urea is a waste product from protein breakdown.
- Creatinine is also a waste product from normal muscle activity.
- Estimated glomerular filtration rate (eGFR) is calculated based on your creatinine level and your age, gender and ethnicity.

Your urea result was **5** mmol/L (Normal range: 2.8 - 7.2).

Your creatinine result was **100** umol/L (Normal range: 74 - 110).

This is a normal result and reflects normal functioning kidneys.

Your eGFR result was **1000** ml/min/1.73m² (Normal range: 90 - 1000).

Your eGFR was normal.

Your potassium result was **5** mmol/L (Normal range: 3.5 - 5.1).

- Your potassium result is normal.

Your sodium result was **140** mmol/L (Normal range: 136 - 145).

- Your sodium result is normal.



Vitamin D

Vitamin D helps regulate the amount of calcium and phosphate in the body. These nutrients are needed to keep bones, teeth and muscles healthy. Without adequate vitamin D, bone diseases such as rickets in children and bone softening (osteomalacia) were seen for many years. The body creates vitamin D from direct sunlight on the skin when outdoors. However, during winter months with less sun, very few people away from the equator can get enough vitamin D from sunlight alone.

Vitamin D is also found in a small number of foods. Food sources include:

- Oily fish such as salmon, sardines, herring and mackerel
- Red meat and liver
- Egg yolks
- Fortified foods such as milk, alternative milks and breakfast cereals

Some studies have shown that low vitamin D levels are associated with an increased risk of cardiovascular disease, obesity and some inflammatory conditions. There are suggestions that increasing your vitamin D levels may also help regulate mood and improve symptoms of depression. However, getting outdoors alone, which naturally increases vitamin D, has been shown to have similar benefits including improving mood and cognitive function.

Your vitamin D level was **100** nmol/L (Normal range: 75 - 124).

Your vitamin D level is in the normal range. You indicated that you take vitamin D and it appears to be working. You may decide to vary your dose of vitamin D between winter and summer months.

Generally adults need 10 micrograms (mcg) of vitamin D a day. This is equivalent to 400 International Units (IU). Some organisations recommend 15 mcg per day (600 IU) during winter and to consider it all year round if you have darker skin tone, reduced sun exposure or have an indoor lifestyle.

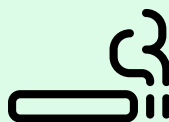


CRP

CRP, or C-reactive protein, is a commonly used blood test to indicate that someone has an infection or an inflammatory process going on. It is quite sensitive, so it can be raised for a number of reasons but broadly speaking they are related to infection or inflammation whether that be from an inflamed muscle, an injury, swelling or a sore throat and this cannot be distinguished on the basis of the test alone. Therefore when CRP is raised you need to put that in the context of clinical symptoms and where the inflammation or infection is.

In the field of cardiac risk profile, a slightly modified version of this test is employed. However, in our current context, we focus on the CRP test to provide us with general insights into the overall inflammatory status and potential infections in the body.

Your result shows your CRP is within the normal range.



Smoking

Smoking tobacco (cigarettes, hand-rolled tobacco, cigars, pipes) or chewing tobacco is well known to be harmful to your health. As well as lung and mouth cancers there are increased risks of chronic lung disease and cardiovascular disease such as heart attacks and strokes.

Nicotine in tobacco is addictive. Most smoking cessation programmes use nicotine replacement therapies (gums, patches, etc) to help with the nicotine cravings. Many e-cigarette (vaping) products contain nicotine and are often used as a substitute for smoking tobacco. With time, increasing problems associated with vaping are being recognised. However, some people find that vaping is the only way they can stop smoking.

You have told us that you have not smoked or vaped. That is really good. The dangers of smoking are well established and vaping is not a safe alternative. These are really healthy choices you have made.



Physical Activity Questionnaire

Physical activity is central to maintaining good cardiovascular health and improving your longevity. Some of the benefits of exercise include:

- maintaining brain health,
- managing your weight and risk of type 2 diabetes,
- maintaining bone density and muscle mass,
- decreasing the risk of cardiovascular disease, stroke and high blood pressure
- decreasing the risk of certain cancers (colon, stomach, breast and lung cancers)
- improving your recovery from some infectious diseases (influenza, pneumonia)
- and improving your ability to perform everyday tasks.

You are meeting the requirements for high levels of physical activity, with appropriate targets for either vigorous or moderate-intensity exercise over the course of the week. You are well placed to benefit from good physical fitness. Your 5-year risk of a major cardiovascular event is 12% less and your 5-year risk of death is 19% less than people who meet the basic World Health Organisation recommendations for physical activity.



Alcohol US-AUDIT

Alcohol is consumed by many people. There can be negative effects from alcohol in the short term (eg. injury, missed opportunities) and also long-term health effects from excessive drinking.

Despite often being consumed in celebratory or social circumstances, alcohol in all forms is associated with depression. It can also cause high blood pressure and increases your risk of heart disease, heart failure and stroke. Additionally, alcohol can cause liver disease and is associated with an increased risk of a number of cancers. It is also associated with low libido, decreased fertility and weight gain.

You completed the US-AUDIT standardised questionnaire, which has been adapted to the drink sizes and national alcohol consumption guidelines specific to your country.

You indicated that you drink alcohol in moderation, which is within the safe drinking limits. To minimise health risks, guidelines recommend spreading alcohol consumption throughout the week rather than consuming your weekly safe allowance in one or two sittings. Additionally, it is recommended to have at least 2 alcohol-free days per week.

You can find more information about alcohol consumption at [NHS Better Health - Alcohol](#)



Diet

Understanding what you eat is the first step toward making positive changes. A balanced diet is crucial for maintaining optimal health, energy levels, and mental clarity. It supports everything from your immune system and heart health to your weight management and mood regulation. By assessing your current dietary habits, you can identify areas where you may be consuming too much or too little of certain nutrients and make adjustments to achieve a healthier balance.

Sugar

Many people find that a sugary snack gives them a boost to keep going during a hard day. Unfortunately, this leads to a dip in energy levels that can leave you exhausted and craving more sugar to get another boost. Comfort eating is not uncommon, but usually involves something sugar based.

It can be very useful to study the reasons behind when you eat or crave sugar, and why. With this understanding, you can plan ahead. For example, some find that substituting a treat for something else they enjoy, like a movie, book or a coffee, can work. Sometimes having your favourite healthy(ish) food ready when you get home can also remove the temptation of an unhealthy quick option.

In spite of your sugar craving your blood test for diabetes is normal and this is reassuring.

Calories

Unhealthy snacks can add up to large amounts of extra calories. Snacks and treats are not always related to hunger; sometimes they are eaten as a reward, to bring joy, to alleviate boredom, or out of habit. Long delays between meals also make snacking more likely. It is worth reflecting on and addressing the reasons why you snack in order to see if it's possible to cut down. Where feasible, planning your meal times and avoiding eating processed carbs, such as breads, pastas and biscuits, might help, as might introducing non-food-related treats as an alternative reward.

Takeaways are often high in calories, salt and cholesterol, and tend to have very large portions. In order to cut down the number of times you get a takeaway, it is worth looking at reasons why you might be getting takeaways and addressing them.

You may be working a long day and/or skipping lunch or are simply too hungry to wait or too tired to cook. Having a takeaway might also be something to look forward to after a hard day in which you did little else that you enjoyed. A harmless (very rare!) treat is reasonable, but avoid having fast food too often.

Protein

It's important to be particularly careful about good quality, lean cuts of meat and keeping processed meat, such as burgers or sausages, to a minimum. Reducing consumption of red meat is also generally accepted as a healthy choice. Overall, your dietary choices seem likely offer sufficient sources of protein. However, growing evidence suggests that lowering meat intake is good for both our bodies and the planet, so it may be good to consider alternative protein sources to meat, such as fish, nuts and plant protein. Generally speaking, most adults will need a daily protein intake of about 0.75g per kg of body weight.

For a long time, eggs were thought to be too high in bad cholesterol. That consensus has changed dramatically. More recently, dieticians have moved towards recommending eggs (usually 1-2 a day) as a good source of protein and, within reason, good fats, including Omega-3. For you, they might be a simple and convenient option for protein.

Dairy foods, on the other hand, are something that dieticians don't always agree on. It's important to be aware of that full fat dairy is a great source of calcium and protein, and is usually quite filling. However, too much dairy can contribute significantly to your daily fat intake.

Fruit, veg & fibre

The World Health Organisation (WHO) recommends eating at least 400g of fruit or vegetables per day, excluding potatoes, sweet potato and other starchy root vegetables. This means that it's recommended to consume about five or more portions of vegetables and at least one piece of fruit per day. Vegetables positively affect your health in numerous ways, impacting everything from your energy levels to your digestion. However, compared to vegetables, most fruit contain less fibre and more sugar. Often, people don't spend as much time thinking about the vegetables they're cooking as they do about the meat, fish or other main protein. Planning a few of your weekly meals around the vegetables can help change that.

There are several advantages to consuming nuts and seeds, particularly due to their Omega-3 content, which some research links with improved cognitive function. Other benefits include anti-inflammatory effects, high protein content and fibre. Although nuts and seeds tend to be quite high in calories, they are a rich source of good quality calories. An easy way to include these in your diet is to add small quantities of flaxseeds, chia seeds and walnuts as a topping on your meals. It's just important to keep in mind that, despite their fibre content, they are unlikely to make up for the lack of fruit or vegetables in your diet.

Difficulty with planning your meals in advance is also often a contributing factor to a lower than normal vegetable intake. Time management and generally making a priority of cooking healthy meals is key.

Carbohydrates

Consuming a high level of processed foods may lead to a deficiency in essential nutrients.

For improved health outcomes, it would be advised to reduce your intake of processed foods and aim to include more whole foods such as vegetables, fruits, lean protein and foods that contain good (unsaturated) fat. Even making this change for just one meal a day can be a beneficial starting point.

Water

Try to drink at least 2 litres of water every day. Water plays an important role in various bodily functions, including maintaining the balance of bodily fluids, aiding digestion, regulating body temperature, and supporting brain function. You may find this hard at first, but it quickly becomes a habit if you take steps such as carrying a reusable water bottle with you, setting reminders on your phone, or if you need to, infusing your water with fruits to improve the taste.

Your kidney blood test, however, did suggest dehydration.

Fats

Balancing your fat intake by focusing on unsaturated fats while limiting saturated fats can help improve heart health and overall well-being. Unsaturated fats come from sources such as olive oil, nuts, seeds, and oily fish. Processed or fatty cuts of meat tend to be high in saturated fat, so opt for lean cuts instead. Desserts often contain cream or butter and therefore are also usually high in saturated fat. When you can try to substitute dessert for a slightly healthier option.

Choosing low-fat dairy products can reduce your intake of saturated fats, potentially lowering your overall risk of cardiovascular disease. However, be mindful that these products can be high in sugar, which in some cases, may pose a greater health risk than the fat content.

Meal routine

Shift workers who eat at irregular times have a higher risk of developing type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular diseases such as strokes, heart attacks, and high blood pressure. While making healthy food choices can be challenging for shift workers, it is possible with some planning.

Disrupted sleep can affect your diet by altering hunger hormones which can lead to increased appetite and cravings for high-calorie, sugary foods. This in turn can result in overeating and poor food choices, contributing to weight gain and metabolic issues. Additionally, sleep deprivation impairs decision-making and self-control, making it harder to resist unhealthy foods. This can complicate meal planning, but a good starting point is to keep a food diary for a few days to track what, when, and why you eat. For example, busy individuals might grab the quickest snack available due to hunger and fatigue. This can be easily avoided by taking a few minutes to prepare lunch the night before.

Planning meals in advance ensures you have the ingredients for nutritious meals at home, reducing the need to run to the shop for convenience foods, which are often deceptively unhealthy. Batch cooking on days off can provide quick and healthy meals that align with your shifts.

Intermittent fasting is a practice that involves limiting your food intake to a set window of time to allow for extended periods of fasting. Common schedules include fasting for 16 hours (often overnight) with an 8-hour eating window, typically from midday to early evening. Some people opt for longer fasts once a week. There are theories suggesting additional benefits, such as reducing inflammatory processes associated with cardiovascular disease and cancer. However, the only widely accepted and medically proven benefit is that the calorie reduction resulting from intermittent fasting typically leads to weight loss. Research in this area is ongoing and may yield new insights over time.

